



A 2020 poll among 1,005 hiring decision-makers by US-based staffing solutions firm Express Employment Professionals found 67 per cent respondents saying they use social networking sites to research potential job candidates. A 2018 CareerBuilder survey carried out in the US found the number to be at 70 per cent. While a similar study could not be found in India, several recruiters and experts in the field admit they do pick up on the digital breadcrumbs left behind by jobseekers. Those, along with their résumé, interviews, psychometric tests, panel discussions and other assessment tools are used to make hiring decisions.

Pooja B. Luthra, Group Chief HR Officer of Trident Group, who has also run her own HR consultancy firm, says it is common these days for most organisations to go for “social media screening” of candidates. “Many of them are even rejecting candidates based on what they find on social media,” she says. APAC President Manish Sinha of background verification company Sterling RISQ, which also conducts social media screening, says, “It is a very natural extension of the normal screening any company would do. You would typically check two aspects of a profile—minimum standards such as criminal history, education, employment background, as well as alignment with corporate culture.” He says many of his top high-volume clients are in India across telecom, media, insurance, consumer banking, staffing firms, accounting and audit firms. Power and gas, private equity and technology firms are also big on social media screening, he adds.

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BETTER SAFE THAN SORRY

For organisations, social media screening is a way to identify red flags and sidestep any potential bombs waiting to detonate because recruitment is expensive as is brand damage. And the latter is often difficult to undo, especially with almost instant social media amplification.

“When an unflattering news article comes out about a person, the organisation’s name also gets dragged in. That tells people the organisation doesn’t have control over the talent it hires. It’s such a difficult thing to manage if you are employing 30,000-40,000 people,” says recruitment firm Randstad India’s Chief People Officer Anjali Raghuvanshi. Trident’s Luthra says you don’t want to feel foolish later on for missing obvious behaviour clues the person had left in the public domain. “Earlier we used to do reference checks by calling up people. Now the person is offering that information. So why not?”

That’s why it is not restricted to industries requiring